

PRIVACY

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ARE WE BEING TRACKED? Many people know, or claim to know that we live in a world of no privacy. Many claim that Google, Apple, and other tech giants are following our every move. And while those who make this claim are not wrong, some claims I have heard are wrong.

MOST USED APPS

When doing research into the privacy of the modern online era, a selection for investigation is needed. So here are the top most used apps for different tasks. For the entire duration of this paper, the focus will be on the USA, so the items on this following list reflect US numbers, not global app popularity.

POPULAR PLATFORMS

These are the most popular messaging apps the USA.

- **Google:** messaging, calls
- **Facebook:** messaging, social media
- **TikTok:** reels, social media
- **Instagram:** reels, social media
- **YouTube:** entertainment, music
- **Apple iMessage:** messaging

- **WhatsApp:** messaging, calls
- **Snapchat:** messaging, social media
- **Telegram:** messaging
- **Skype:** calls
- **Talkatone:** calls
- **Spotify:** music
- **Pandora:** music
- **Netflix:** entertainment
- **Disney+:** entertainment
- **Tubi:** entertainment
- **Hulu:** entertainment
- **Max:** entertainment
- **The Roku Channel:** entertainment
- **Amazon Prime Video:** entertainment

GOOGLE

If You're Signed In to a Google Account

When logged in, Google can associate searches directly with your account.

SIGNED IN

1. Your full search terms: everything you type into the search bar.
2. What you click on after searching: websites, images, videos.
3. Time and date of each search.
4. Device type: phone, laptop, tablet, etc.
5. Browser info: Chrome, Safari, Edge, etc.
6. Operating system: Android, iOS, Windows, macOS.
7. Your IP address: tells them your approximate location or your precise location (if Location Services or Maps are on).
8. Search location: where you were when you searched (city, sometimes exact coordinates).
9. Language and country settings.
10. Network info: Wi-Fi name, carrier, or mobile data source.
11. Unique device IDs: serials, advertising IDs, phone identifiers.
12. Cookies and ad trackers linking your device to your Google profile.
13. Voice data if you use voice search or Assistant.
14. Apps and services you used before or after the search.
15. Inferred interests: topics Google thinks you care about (politics, sports, religion, shopping habits, etc.).
16. Search patterns: what times of day you usually search, what topics repeat.
17. Location history: if enabled, Google keeps a map of places you've been.
18. Click history and navigation: what links you followed, how long you stayed.
19. Ad interactions: which ads you saw or tapped.

Google still sees a lot, but can't link it to your name directly.

NOT SIGNED IN

1. Your search terms (the exact text).
2. What you click on from results.
3. Your IP address (used to guess your region or city).
4. Browser and device info (phone/computer type, software, screen size).
5. Operating system and browser version.
6. Approximate location (from IP address or Wi-Fi).
7. Cookies: small trackers that give your browser a unique ID.
8. Device ID or advertising ID (unique number tied to your phone/browser).
9. Time and date of searches.
10. Language and regional settings.
11. Ad and click behavior (what you interacted with).
12. Search frequency and topics (used to infer general interests).

Google claims they do not sell any of your data. And they claim to keep everything private.

In settings, users can set their browser data to auto-delete at three, 18, or 36 months. Even after user deletion, data may persist in backups or for legal compliance (e.g., subpoenas). No clear timeline provided.

FACEBOOK

When signed in to Facebook, they track the following.

SIGNED IN

1. Profile info: name, email, phone number, birthday, gender, profile picture
2. Content you post: status updates, photos, videos, comments, messages
3. Interactions: likes, shares, reactions, story views
4. Friends and connections: friend list, groups joined, event RSVPs, followers
5. Location data: GPS coordinates if enabled, IP-derived location, check-ins, nearby places
6. Device info: device type (phone, computer, tablet), operating system, browser type and version, device identifiers
7. Usage data: time spent on platform, pages visited, clicks, session duration, scrolling behavior
8. Third-party activity: apps and websites using Facebook tools (Like button, Facebook Login), purchases, activity from partners
9. Payment info: credit/debit card details or other payment methods if used on Facebook
10. Network info: Wi-Fi networks, mobile carrier, connection type
11. Voice and audio: voice recordings or commands via Facebook/Meta apps if enabled
12. Camera and microphone: if you allow apps to access them, for features like video calls or AR
13. Search history: searches performed within Facebook or using Facebook services
14. Advertising interactions: ads viewed, clicked, skipped, or reacted to
15. Inferred interests: topics, hobbies, political or religious interests inferred from activity
16. Location patterns: regular places visited, movement patterns
17. Device identifiers: advertising IDs, cookies, browser fingerprints
18. Security information: login attempts, account recovery data, IP addresses for security checks
19. Interaction with content: how long you watch videos, pause/skip behavior, link clicks
20. App usage patterns: interactions with Facebook apps or affiliated apps

NOT SIGNED IN

1. Browsing behavior: websites using Facebook tools, buttons, or pixels
2. Device info: type, operating system, browser version, device identifiers
3. Location: approximate location derived from IP address
4. Search/referral info: what brought you to a website (referring site or search engine)
5. Interaction with embedded content: clicking on Like or Share buttons on third-party websites
6. Cookies and local storage: for identifying your device and tracking repeat visits
7. Advertising interactions: ads seen, clicked, or ignored
8. Network info: IP address, connection type, mobile carrier
9. Inferred interests: based on browsing behavior across the web